

HOUSE No. 4650

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES, October 27, 2025.

The committee on Higher Education, to whom was referred the petition (accompanied by bill, House, No. 1423) of Christine P. Barber, Michael P. Kushmerek and others that the Department of Education create and administer a field placement grant program to ensure a stable, diverse workforce of licensed social workers, reports recommending that the accompanying bill (House, No. 4650) ought to pass.

For the committee,

DAVID M. ROGERS.

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In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act relative to social work uplifting practices and exam removal.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 SECTION 1. The first paragraph of section 131 of chapter 112 of the General Laws is
2 hereby amended by striking out the words “has passed an examination prepared by the board for
3 this purpose;”.

4 SECTION 2. The first sentence of the first paragraph of section 132 of chapter 112 of the
5 General Laws is hereby amended by striking out the words “Examinations for licensed certified
6 social workers, including those in independent clinical practice” and inserting in place thereof
7 the following words:- Examinations for licensed independent clinical social workers.

8 SECTION 3. Chapter 112 of the General Laws is hereby amended by inserting after
9 section 135C the following section:-

10 Section 135D. To ensure a stable, diverse workforce of licensed social workers in the
11 commonwealth, and to provide for increased support and retention of practicing licensed social
12 workers, the commonwealth shall administer a paid practicum placement grant program for
13 Master of Social Work (MSW) students in good standing. The program shall, subject to

appropriation, provide grant funding to designated recipients with a specific focus on recruiting and retaining MSW students from historically marginalized communities and low-income communities. Funds to establish this program shall be allocated from state, federal, or other dedicated resources, including existing trust funds.

Eligible applicants must attend a school of social work Masters program physically located in Massachusetts that has been accredited by the Council on Social Work Education.

Applicant data, including application details submitted, shall be tracked by the executive office so that the program efficacy and equity can be evaluated.

SECTION 4. Section 136 of chapter 112 of the General Laws is hereby amended by inserting after the fourth paragraph the following paragraph:-

Licensed independent clinical social workers engaged in independent clinical practice who provide one-on-one supervision to a licensed certified social worker, licensed social worker, Masters of social work intern, or Bachelors of social work intern, shall be eligible to receive up to 8 continuing education credits during a licensing period for this supervision.

SECTION 5. The executive office of health and human services shall conduct an evaluation of the impact of removal of the licensing examination requirement for Licensed Certified Social Workers under sections 1 and 2, should it deem such an evaluation necessary. The evaluation may include an analysis of the impact of removing the examination requirement on alleviating shortages of qualified social workers, expanding access to quality behavioral health services, increasing the diversity of the social worker workforce among diverse language skills, race, ethnicity, and cultural backgrounds, and the impact of any increase in diversity on patient care, particularly for vulnerable populations. In preparing the evaluation, the consultant

shall meet with representatives of organizations representing social workers, social work education, social work testing providers, social work patients, behavioral health advocacy organizations, and other groups that may assist the evaluation. The evaluation and analysis shall be conducted independently of the executive office. The executive office shall submit the evaluation to the committee on higher education, the committee on mental health, substance use and recovery and the house and senate committees on ways and means no later than the year in which said evaluation was initiated.

SECTION 6. Sections 1 and 2 are hereby repealed.

SECTION 7. Sections 1 and 2 shall take effect on January 1, 2027. Section 6 shall take effect on December 31, 2030.